



Kale.

DIFFICULTY
Fairly Easy

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Kale, also known as borecole, is a hardy, non-hearting brassica grown for its leaves and young spring shoots. It used to be treated as a plain winter standby, but modern varieties give a wide range of colours, textures and flavours, from deeply curled green leaves to red and flat-leaved types. It is one of the most dependable crops for autumn, winter and early spring, often standing when little else is available, and the flavour is generally better after frost.

Quick facts

**Sow**

Mar – Jun

**Germination**

7–12 days

**Row spacing**

15 cm between seed rows

**Harvest**

Sep – Apr

**Depth**

1 cm

**Yield per plant**

0.91 kg



Plant spacing About 45 cm between standard plants; allow more room for large varieties. Follow the packet for compact or baby-leaf crops.



Ready in First picking depends on variety and leaf size; main crops give autumn/winter leaves and later spring shoots.

Growing calendar



Core needs

1 = low · 5 = high



Sun

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Water

● ● ● ● ● 3/5



Nutrition

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Recommended varieties

MODERN AND COLOURED**Nero di Toscana**

A dark, strap-leaved kale for repeated picking. Its textured leaves are especially useful in soups, stews and winter cooking.

CURLY-LEAVED**Reflex F1**

A green curly kale for productive winter picking. A useful maincrop choice where familiar curled leaves are preferred.

MODERN AND COLOURED**Red Russian**

A flat-leaved kale with purple stems and tender young leaves. Useful for salads when young and cooking when larger.

MODERN AND COLOURED**Redbor F1**

A purple-red curly kale that adds colour to the plot. Pick regularly for tender leaves and continued growth.

MODERN AND COLOURED**Yurok F1**

A dark-leaved kale in the Tuscan style. Retain as a modern alternative where this leaf shape is preferred.

Key risks

**Cabbage Caterpillars**

Caterpillars of cabbage white butterfly, cabbage moth and related pests chew holes in leaves.

**Club Root (Finger and Toe)**

Swollen, distorted roots cause poor growth and wilting in sunshine.

**Cabbage Whitefly**

Small white-winged insects and scale-like young live below brassica leaves; adults fly up when disturbed.

**Mealy Aphid**

Large clusters of waxy, greyish 'greenflies' occur on the underside of leaves and tips of plants from June onwards in hot, dry weather.

Growing & harvesting



Fertile, settled soil

Drain well; firm transplants.

Keep plants steady

Water; prevent wind rock.

Spring feeding

Feed only weak spring growth.

Soil & preparation

1. Choose sun or light shade and well-drained soil. Kale tolerates many soils but yields best in fertile ground.
2. Follow early crops; weed and add mature compost as needed. Use settled or no-dig soil. Firm transplants without compacting wet ground; lime only if a soil test indicates a need.

Sowing & planting

1 Raise young plants



Sow thinly in a seed bed or modules; cover and thin seedlings.

2 Set deeper and firm



Set lowest leaves just above soil; firm well and water in.

Final rows Usually 45–60 cm apart for full-size plants; adjust for variety and method.

Transplant height 10–15 cm

Rape kale: sow direct and thin in stages.

Water nursery rows before lifting. After early crops, sow June–early July; transplant promptly when ready, often July–early August. Allow establishment time and protect all crops from pests.

Looking after the crop

1. Weed carefully and water young plants. Check and secure loose stems after windy weather, without treading heavily on wet soil.
2. Remove yellow leaves, earth up in autumn and stake tall plants on exposed sites.
3. Support insect-proof mesh where needed and secure bird protection. Keep covers clear of leaves and check beneath them; leaf colour gives no immunity.
4. Give an organic liquid feed only if spring growth is weak.

Harvesting & storage

- Pick tender outer leaves little and often. Leave the growing top and enough foliage for repeat crops; reject tough or yellow leaves.
- Pick young, tender side shoots in late winter and spring, usually about 10–12 cm long; timing varies with variety and weather. Removing a mature crown encourages shoots; this is a separate method, not routine leaf picking.
- Pick Red Russian leaves young; baby-leaf harvest is not limited to spring. Chop healthy finished stems into short 10–15 cm pieces to help them compost; follow disease guidance for affected roots.

Pests & diseases

Problem	What to look for	What to do
Cabbage Caterpillars	Holes; feeding caterpillars.	Hand-pick eggs and larvae; use fine mesh.
Club Root (Finger and Toe)	Swollen roots; wilting.	Avoid infected soil; clean tools. Test before liming; no cure.
Cabbage Whitefly	White flies under leaves.	Tolerate minor colonies; encourage natural enemies.
Mealy Aphid	Grey colonies; curled leaves.	Squash damaging colonies; encourage predators.
Pigeons	Pecked or stripped leaves.	Net securely, clear of leaves.
Slugs and Snails	Holes; seedlings eaten.	Hand-pick at dusk; clear yellow leaves near seedlings.
Cabbage Root Fly	Wilting; tunnelled roots.	Use collars or mesh on a rotated bed.
Flea Beetle	Tiny holes; jumping beetles.	Mesh young plants; keep growth steady.

Final tips



Match spacing to variety and method; give larger plants more room.



Winter-worn plants may still provide tender spring shoots.

Carrot and Parsnip

Troubles

Carrots and parsnips share several root pests and diseases. Carrots are especially vulnerable to carrot fly; parsnips also suffer from old seed and canker. Start with fresh seed, deep well-prepared soil and a clean seedbed. Avoid fresh manure; use resistant varieties where available.

Recognise → Act → Prevent

PARSNIP

Old Seed / Poor Germination

RECOGNISE Old seed, cold or dry soil and deep sowing can all delay or prevent emergence. Check conditions before resowing.

ACT Sow again with fresh seed if the season still allows.

PREVENT Use fresh seed each year. Keep the drill moist until seedlings emerge; a few radish seeds can mark the row.



CARROT

Green Top

RECOGNISE Sunlight turns exposed carrot crowns green. Unlike green potatoes, green carrots are not harmful, but look unsightly.

PREVENT Earth up around exposed crowns during the growing season.



PARSNIP

Parsnip Rust Fungus

RECOGNISE Rust-coloured crown damage may resemble staining or canker; the precise cause needs confirmation.

ACT Lift and discard badly affected roots.

PREVENT Improve drainage, avoid root injury and seek a diagnosis before choosing a long crop break.



CARROT

Clayburn

RECOGNISE Carrot surface damage associated with clay; check for pests or rot. The cause is uncertain.

ACT Inspect affected roots; seek identification for recurring damage. Discard active decay.

PREVENT Prepare well-drained, workable soil; use a raised bed where necessary.



CARROT / PARSNIP

Carrot Fly

Tunnelled roots

RECOGNISE Leaves turn reddish, then yellow. Maggots tunnel in carrots or damage parsnip surfaces. Seedlings may die; roots may rot.

ACT No cure. Minor surface damage on large parsnips may be trimmed away.

PREVENT Cover completely with insect-proof mesh on rotated ground. Sow thinly. Carrots sown after mid-May or lifted before late August may avoid peak attacks.



CARROT / PARSNIP

Fanging

Forked roots

RECOGNISE Roots fork when tips meet stones, compaction or injury. Fresh manure and uneven seedbeds can contribute.

ACT There is no treatment for an already forked root.

PREVENT Prepare workable soil, remove larger stones and avoid compaction or fresh manure before sowing.

